feasts and rituals. When the apocalypse didn't materialise and the community almost starved, Baninge's power collapsed. Though some locals continued to believe that he and Tanotka were divine messengers, many others concluded that the two were charlatans – or perhaps the servants of the Devil.[3]

How could people distinguish the true will of the gods from the inventions or imaginations of fallible humans? Unless you had a personal divine revelation, knowing what the gods said meant trusting what fallible humans like Tanotka and Baninge claimed the gods said. But how could you trust these humans, especially if you didn't know them personally? Religion wanted to take fallible humans out of the loop and give people access to infallible superhuman laws, but religion repeatedly boiled down to trusting this or that human.

One way around this problem was to create religious institutions that vetted the purported divine messengers. Already in tribal societies communication with superhuman entities like tribal spirits was often the domain of religious experts. Among the Baining people, specialised spirit mediums known as *agungaraga* were traditionally responsible for communicating with the spirits and thereby learning the hidden causes of misfortunes ranging from illness to crop failure. Their membership in an established institution made the *agungaraga* more trustworthy than Tanotka and Baninge, and made their authority more stable and widely acknowledged.[4] Among the Kalapalo tribe of Brazil religious rituals were organised by hereditary ritual officers known as the *anetaū*. In ancient Celtic and Hindu societies similar duties were the preserve of druids and Brahmins.[5] As human societies grew and became more complex, so did their religious institutions. Priests and oracles had to train long and hard for the important task of representing the gods, so people no longer needed to trust just any layperson who claimed to have met an angel or to carry a divine message.[6] In ancient Greece, for example, if you wanted to know what the gods said, you went to an accredited expert like the Pythia – the high priestess at the temple of Apollo in Delphi.

But as long as religious institutions like oracular temples were staffed by fallible humans, they too were open to error and corruption. Herodotus recounts that when Athens was ruled by the tyrant Hippias, the pro-democracy faction bribed the Pythia to help them. Whenever any Spartan